Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيَامُ

"O you who believe, fasting has been prescribed for you." (al-Baqarah 2:183)

The Fiqh of Fasting

Ramaḍān and voluntary fasts in the Mālikī school: intention, what breaks the fast, qaḍāʾ, kaffārah, fidyah and zakāt al-fiṭr.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Fasting the month of Ramaḍān is the fourth pillar of Islām. Allah prescribed it so that we may gain taqwā (al-Baqarah 2:183), and the Prophet ﷺ promised: “Whoever fasts Ramaḍān out of faith and hoping for reward, his previous sins will be forgiven” (al-Bukhārī 38, Muslim 760). Allah says in a ḥadīth qudsī: “Every deed of the son of Ādam is for him, except fasting: it is for Me, and I will reward it” (al-Bukhārī 1904, Muslim 1151). And in Paradise there is a gate called **ar-Rayyān**, through which only those who fasted will enter (al-Bukhārī, 1896).

This guide explains the rulings of fasting according to the school of **Imām Mālik**, following al-Akhḍarī, al-ʿAshmāwiyyah, the Risālah and the Muwaṭṭaʾ. Read it before Ramaḍān, so that you enter the month knowing what to do.

A note on the Mālikī school

Some Mālikī rulings on fasting differ from what you may hear from people of other schools. For example, in the Mālikī school the **intention must be made at night** even for voluntary fasts, one who **eats by mistake** in Ramaḍān must make up the day, and **kaffārah** is due for deliberate eating and drinking, not only for intercourse. These are explained in their places, with the reasons.

Modern questions (injections, inhalers, drips) are answered by today’s scholars; the guide gives the common view and asks you to check with a teacher.

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Part 1 Ramaḍān and who must fast

The beginning and end of the month

Ramaḍān begins with one of two things: **sighting the new moon** on the night of the 30th of Shaʿbān, or **completing thirty days** of Shaʿbān. The Prophet ﷺ said: "Fast when you see it and break your fast when you see it. If it is hidden from you, complete the count of Shaʿbān as thirty" (al-Bukhārī 1909, Muslim 1081). In the Mālikī school the sighting is established by **two upright witnesses**, or by a large number of people seeing it. The end of Ramaḍān is established the same way. Follow the announcement of the Muslim authority in your country, so that the community fasts and celebrates together.

Do not fast the **day of doubt** (the 30th of Shaʿbān when the moon was hidden) as a precaution for Ramaḍān. The school does not allow it, and such a fast does not count for Ramaḍān even if the day turns out to be the first of the month. ʿAmmār said: "Whoever fasts the day about which there is doubt has disobeyed Abū al-Qāsim ﷺ" (Abū Dāwūd 2334, at-Tirmidhī 686).

Who must fast

Fasting Ramaḍān is obligatory on every Muslim who is **sane**, has reached **puberty**, is **able** to fast, is **resident** (not travelling), and, for a woman, is **free of ḥayḍ and nifās**. Children are not obliged, but parents should train them gradually, as the Companions did, giving them toys of wool to distract them until iftār (al-Bukhārī 1960, Muslim 1136).

Who is excused

Person	Ruling	What they owe
The sick	May break the fast if fasting harms them, increases the illness or delays recovery. Must break it if fasting would cause serious harm.	Qaḍāʾ when well
The traveller	May break the fast on a journey of about 80 km (four burud) or more, if he set out **before dawn**. Fasting is better for one who is able.	Qaḍāʾ
The pregnant woman	May break the fast if she fears for herself or her baby.	Qaḍāʾ only
The nursing mother	May break the fast if she fears for her baby and cannot hire a wet-nurse or the baby will not take another.	Qaḍāʾ and fidyah
The very old, or the chronically ill	Excused if they cannot fast and will not become able.	No qaḍāʾ; fidyah is recommended
Women in ḥayḍ or nifās	Forbidden to fast; the fast is not valid.	Qaḍāʾ
Extreme hunger or thirst	One who fears death or serious harm must break the fast.	Qaḍāʾ

In the Mālikī school, a traveller who is still at home at dawn must begin the day fasting; if he sets out during the day, he should complete the fast, and if he breaks it, he owes qaḍāʾ (and some say kaffārah). Allah says: “So whoever among you is ill or on a journey, then an equal number of other days… Allah intends ease for you and does not intend hardship” (al-Baqarah 2:185).

Part 2 The intention and the farāʾiḍ of fasting

The intention (niyyah)

The intention is made in the heart, **at night**, between sunset and dawn. The Prophet ﷺ said: "Whoever does not intend the fast before dawn, there is no fast for him" (Abū Dāwūd 2454, an-Nasāʾī 2331). In the Mālikī school this applies to **every** fast, obligatory or voluntary.

For Ramaḍān, **one intention on the first night** is enough for the whole month, because it is one continuous act of worship, as long as the fasting is not broken by an excuse such as travel, illness or ḥayḍ. When the fast is broken by such an excuse, a new intention is made each night until the continuity returns. It is recommended to renew the intention every night. Eating suḥūr with the thought of fasting is itself an intention.

The farāʾiḍ of fasting

1. **The intention** at night, as above.
2. **Abstaining from food and drink** from true dawn (Fajr) until the sun has completely set: anything that reaches the throat or stomach through the mouth, the nose, the ear or the eye.
3. **Abstaining from intercourse**, and from causing the emission of manī or madhy, by any means.
4. **Abstaining from deliberate vomiting.**

> وَكُلُوا وَاشْرَبُوا حَتَّىٰ يَتَبَيَّنَ لَكُمُ الْخَيْطُ الْأَبْيَضُ مِنَ الْخَيْطِ الْأَسْوَدِ مِنَ الْفَجْرِ ۖ ثُمَّ أَتِمُّوا الصِّيَامَ إِلَى اللَّيْلِ
>
> **"And eat and drink until the white thread of dawn becomes distinct to you from the black thread [of night]. Then complete the fast until the night."**
>
> Al-Baqarah 2:187.

If you eat thinking it is still night and then learn that dawn had come, or break the fast thinking the sun had set and then learn it had not, you owe **qaḍāʾ** of that day, and must abstain for the rest of it. If you are unsure whether dawn has come, stop eating: eating while in doubt about dawn is forbidden in the school.

Part 3 What breaks the fast, and what does not

Breaks the fast	Does not break the fast
Eating or drinking, even a little, deliberately or by mistake	Swallowing your own saliva
Smoking, or deliberately inhaling smoke, incense or steam that reaches the throat	Dust of the road, flour for the baker, or a fly entering the throat without choice
Anything reaching the throat through the nose, ear or eye, such as nose drops, ear drops or eye drops that are tasted in the throat	Kohl or eye drops that do not reach the throat (but kohl is disliked in the day)
Deliberate vomiting	Vomiting that overcomes you, if nothing is swallowed back
Intercourse, even without emission	A wet dream
Emission of manī by kissing, touching, looking repeatedly or thinking persistently	Waking up in janābah: do ghusl and fast
Emission of madhy by such causes (qaḍāʾ only)	Rinsing the mouth and nose gently in wuḍūʾ
Toothpaste or mouthwash that is swallowed	Siwāk with a dry stick
Breaking the intention: deciding firmly to stop fasting	Blood tests and taking blood

Eating by mistake

The Prophet ﷺ said: “Whoever forgets while fasting and eats or drinks, let him complete his fast, for it is Allah who fed him and gave him drink” (al-Bukhārī 1933, Muslim 1155). In the Mālikī school, the one who forgets is **not sinful** and **must complete** the day without eating, as the ḥadīth says; but if the fast was **obligatory**, such as Ramaḍān, he **makes up** the day afterwards. Imām Mālik understood the ḥadīth to remove the sin and the kaffārah, and held that a fast which did not have its pillar (abstaining from the whole day) must be made up, as with forgetting a rakʿah. In a voluntary fast, there is nothing to make up.

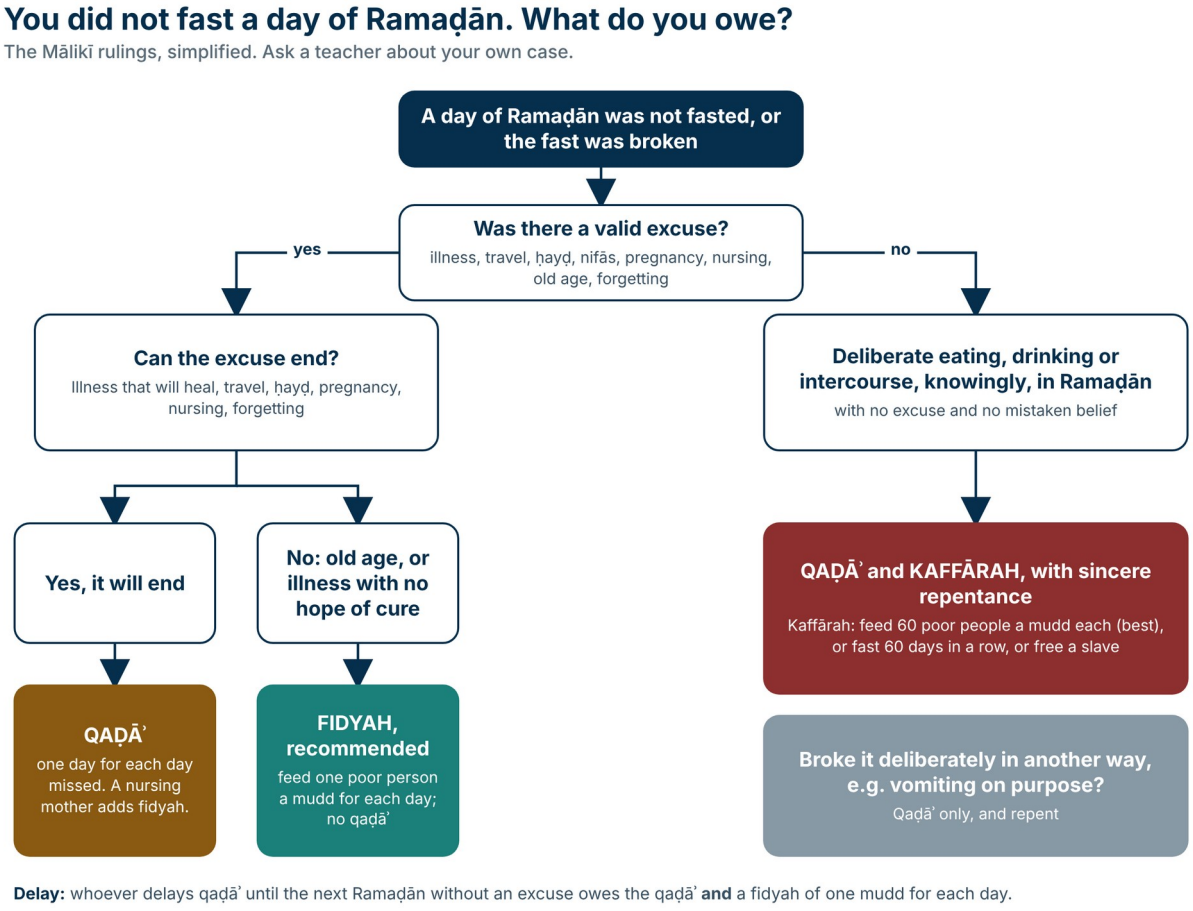
For students

Modern questions. Most contemporary scholars, including those of the Mālikī school, hold that:

- **Nutritional drips** (glucose, feeding through a vein) break the fast.
- **Non-nutritional injections** (vaccines, insulin, antibiotics into the muscle) do not break the fast, though it is better to take them at night if possible.
- **Asthma inhalers** are disputed: many scholars say they break the fast because a substance reaches the throat, and that the asthmatic who needs one daily is excused and makes up the days; others permit them. Ask a teacher.
- **Tablets placed under the tongue**, if nothing is swallowed, and **blood tests** do not break the fast.

When in doubt about a medicine, ask a scholar and a doctor; never stop necessary medicine on your own.

Part 4 Qaḍāʾ, kaffārah and fidyah



Delay: whoever delays qaḍāʾ until the next Ramaḍān without an excuse owes the qaḍāʾ **and** a fidyah of one mudd for each day.

Term	What it is	When it is due
Qaḍāʾ	Making up a missed day, one day for each day. It may be done separately or in a row; making it up soon is better.	Whenever an obligatory fast was missed or broken, with or without an excuse (except for the permanently unable).
Kaffārah	Expiation: feeding sixty poor people a mudd each, which is the best in the Mālikī school; or fasting sixty days in a row; or freeing a slave. One kaffārah for each day broken.	Breaking a day of **Ramaḍān** deliberately, knowingly, by **eating, drinking or intercourse**, or by deliberately bringing about the emission of manī, with no excuse and no mistaken belief.
Fidyah	Feeding one poor person a mudd of food for each day.	The nursing mother who breaks for her baby; one who delays qaḍāʾ past the next Ramaḍān without excuse; recommended for the old and chronically ill.

A **mudd** is the measure of the Prophet's ﷺ two cupped hands, about **0.5 to 0.6 kg** of the staple food of the land, such as rice, maize, millet or beans. The kaffārah is based on the Companion who came saying "I am ruined!", having had intercourse with his wife in Ramaḍān. The Prophet ﷺ asked if he could free a slave, then if he could fast two months in a row, then if he could feed sixty poor people, and gave him a basket of dates to give in charity (al-Bukhārī 1936, Muslim 1111).

The Mālikī school applies kaffārah to deliberate **eating and drinking** as well as intercourse, because what makes it due is the deliberate violation of the sanctity of a day of Ramaḍān. There is no kaffārah for breaking a qaḍāʾ day, a vow or a voluntary fast. But in the Mālikī school, deliberately breaking a **voluntary** fast without an excuse is forbidden, and the day must be made up.

Part 5 Sunnah and disliked acts

What is recommended

- **Suḥūr**, and delaying it close to dawn: "Eat suḥūr, for in suḥūr there is blessing" (al-Bukhārī 1923, Muslim 1095).
- **Hastening the ifṭār** as soon as the sun has set: "People will remain upon good as long as they hasten to break the fast" (al-Bukhārī 1957, Muslim 1098).
- Breaking the fast with **fresh dates**, or dry dates, or water (Abū Dāwūd 2356, at-Tirmidhī 696).
- Making **duʿā'** while fasting and at ifṭār, and saying after breaking the fast: "**Dhahaba aẓ-ẓamaʾu wabtallati al-ʿurūqu wa thabata al-ajru in shāʾ Allāh**" (The thirst is gone, the veins are moistened, and the reward is assured, if Allah wills) (Abū Dāwūd, 2357).
- **Guarding the tongue** and the limbs. "Whoever does not give up false speech and acting upon it, Allah has no need of his giving up his food and drink" (al-Bukhārī, 1903). If someone insults you, say: "I am fasting."
- Feeding fasting people, reading much **Qur'an**, giving **charity**, and **iʿtikāf** in the last ten nights.

What is disliked (makrūh)

- **Tasting** food or salt without need, even if you spit it out.
- **Kissing, embracing** or looking with desire, for one who fears it will lead to emission or more.
- **Exaggerating** in rinsing the mouth and nose.
- **Siwāk** with a moist stick that has a taste.
- Applying **kohl** or putting oil or medicine in the ear during the day, in case it reaches the throat.
- **Cupping**, or anything that weakens the faster, for one who fears it will make him break the fast.
- Spending the day **sleeping** and wasting the month in idleness.

Part 6 Tarāwīḥ, iʿtikāf and Laylat al-Qadr

Tarāwīḥ (qiyām Ramaḍān)

The night prayer of Ramaḍān is a confirmed sunnah. “Whoever stands in prayer in Ramaḍān out of faith and hoping for reward, his previous sins will be forgiven” (al-Bukhārī 37, Muslim 759). The Prophet ﷺ led it in congregation for some nights, then stopped for fear it would be made obligatory (al-Bukhārī 2012). ʿUmar later gathered the people behind one reciter (al-Bukhārī 2010). The people of Madinah in Mālik’s time prayed **thirty-six** rakʿahs with three of witr; others prayed twenty, or eight with witr as ʿĀ’ishah described of the Prophet’s ﷺ own prayer (al-Bukhārī 2013). All are sound practices; what matters is praying it well, with presence of heart.

Iʿtikāf

Iʿtikāf is staying in the masjid with the intention of worship. The Prophet ﷺ used to make iʿtikāf in the last ten days of Ramaḍān until Allah took him (al-Bukhārī 2026, Muslim 1172). In the Mālikī school it must be in a **masjid**, preferably one where Jumuʿah is prayed if Friday falls in it; the one in iʿtikāf must be **fasting**; its minimum is a day and a night, and ten days is recommended. He leaves only for necessities such as the toilet, ghusl and food that cannot be brought to him, and he does not visit the sick or attend funerals.

Laylat al-Qadr

> لَيْلَةُ الْقَدْرِ خَيْرٌ مِّنْ أَلْفِ شَهْرٍ
>
> **“The Night of Decree is better than a thousand months.”**
>
> Al-Qadr 97:3.

Laylat al-Qadr is in the **last ten nights** of Ramaḍān, most likely in the **odd nights**: “Seek Laylat al-Qadr in the odd nights of the last ten of Ramaḍān” (al-Bukhārī, 2017). Its time is hidden so that the believer strives in all of them. ʿĀ’ishah asked what she should say if she knew which night it was. He said: say

> اللَّهُمَّ إِنَّكَ عَفُوٌّ تُحِبُّ الْعَفْوَ فَاعْفُ عَنِّي
>
> **“O Allah, You are Pardoning and love to pardon, so pardon me.”**
>
> At-Tirmidhī (3513), who said: ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ.

Part 7 Zakāt al-fiṭr

Ibn ʿUmar said: "The Messenger of Allah ﷺ made zakāt al-fiṭr obligatory: a ṣāʿ of dates or a ṣāʿ of barley, on every Muslim, slave and free, male and female, young and old, and commanded that it be given before the people go out to the prayer" (al-Bukhārī 1503, Muslim 984). Ibn ʿAbbās said it purifies the one who fasted from idle talk and indecency, and feeds the poor (Abū Dāwūd, 1609).

Question	The Mālikī answer
Who must pay?	Every Muslim who has, on the day of ʿĪd, more than the food he and his dependants need for that day. He pays for himself and for those he is obliged to support: his wife, young children and needy parents.
How much?	One **ṣāʿ** (four mudds) for each person: about **2 to 2.5 kg** of the most common staple food of the land, such as rice, maize, millet, beans or gari.
Money instead of food?	The well-known view of the school is that it must be given as **food**, following the Sunnah. Some scholars permit its value in money when that is more useful to the poor; follow your teacher.
When?	It becomes due at sunset on the last day of Ramaḍān (or dawn of ʿĪd, by another view). Best: after Fajr on ʿĪd, before the ʿĪd prayer. It may be given one or two days early. Delaying it past the day of ʿĪd is sinful, but it is still owed.
To whom?	To the **poor and needy Muslims**, not to the other categories of zakāh.

Part 8 The voluntary fasts of the year

Fast	Its virtue
Six days of Shawwāl	"Whoever fasts Ramaḍān and follows it with six of Shawwāl, it is as if he fasted all time" (Muslim, 1164). Imām Mālik disliked joining them directly to the day of ʿĪd, lest people think they are part of Ramaḍān; fasting them later in Shawwāl, or after it, avoids this.
The day of ʿArafah (9 Dhul-Ḥijjah)	For those not performing Ḥajj: "It expiates the year before and the year after" (Muslim, 1162).
ʿĀshūrāʾ (10 Muḥarram)	"It expiates the year before" (Muslim, 1162). Fasting the 9th with it is recommended (Muslim, 1134).
The month of Muḥarram	"The best fasting after Ramaḍān is in Allah's month of Muḥarram" (Muslim, 1163).
Shaʿbān	The Prophet ﷺ fasted more in Shaʿbān than in any month other than Ramaḍān (al-Bukhārī 1969, Muslim 1156).
Mondays and Thursdays	"Deeds are presented on Monday and Thursday, and I love that my deeds are presented while I am fasting" (at-Tirmidhī, 747). Monday is also the day he ﷺ was born (Muslim, 1162).
Three days of each month	Fasting three days a month is like fasting all time (al-Bukhārī 1979, Muslim 1159).
The first nine days of Dhul-Ḥijjah	No days are better for good deeds than these ten (al-Bukhārī, 969).

Days when fasting is forbidden

- The day of **ʿĪd al-Fiṭr** and the day of **ʿĪd al-Aḍḥā** (al-Bukhārī 1990, Muslim 1137).
- The **days of tashrīq** (11–13 Dhul-Ḥijjah), "days of eating and drinking" (Muslim, 1141), except for a pilgrim who has no sacrificial animal.
- A woman's voluntary fast while her husband is present, without his permission (al-Bukhārī, 5195).

Plan A Ramaḍān plan

Use this page in Shaʿbān to prepare, and keep it beside you during the month.

Before Ramaḍān	During the day	During the night
Make up any missed fasts from last year	Pray the five prayers on time, in congregation if you can	Hasten the iftār with dates and water, and make duʿāʾ
Learn the rulings in this guide	Read a fixed portion of Qur'an daily	Pray Tarāwīḥ
Set a Qur'an goal for the month	Guard the tongue: no backbiting, arguing or lying	Eat a light suḥūr close to dawn
Fast some days of Shaʿbān	Give charity, even a little, every day	In the last ten: iʿtikāf, qiyām and the duʿāʾ of Laylat al-Qadr
Settle disputes and seek forgiveness	Keep your phone and screen time small	Pay zakāt al-fiṭr before the ʿĪd prayer

Missed fasts record

Day missed	Reason	Made up on	Fidyah given?

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **In the Mālikī school, the intention for a voluntary fast must be made:**

   a) Before noon b) At night, before dawn c) Any time in the day d) It is not needed

2. **For Ramaḍān, how often is the intention required, if the fast is not interrupted?**

   a) Every night b) Every week c) Once, on the first night d) Before each meal

3. You ate by mistake during a day of Ramaḍān. In the Mālikī school you:

a) Stop fasting for the day b) Owe kaffārah c) Complete the day and make it up later d) Owe nothing at all

4. Which of these requires kaffārah in the Mālikī school?

a) Deliberately drinking in Ramaḍān b) Vomiting by accident c) Eating by mistake d) Breaking a qaḍāʾ day

5. The best form of kaffārah in the Mālikī school is:

a) Freeing a slave b) Feeding sixty poor people c) Fasting sixty days d) Paying money to the masjid

6. A nursing mother who breaks the fast fearing for her baby owes:

a) Nothing b) Qaḍāʾ only c) Kaffārah d) Qaḍāʾ and fidyah

7. A pregnant woman who breaks the fast fearing for her baby owes:

a) Qaḍāʾ only b) Qaḍāʾ and fidyah c) Kaffārah d) Fidyah only

8. Someone delays qaḍāʾ past the next Ramaḍān without excuse. They owe:

a) Nothing more b) Kaffārah c) The qaḍāʾ and a mudd for each day d) Double the days

9. Does a blood test break the fast?

a) Yes b) No c) Only in Ramaḍān d) Only if more than a cup

10. How much is zakāt al-fiṭr for each person?

a) A mudd b) A ṣāʿ of staple food c) 2.5% of savings d) Whatever you like

11. When is the best time to give zakāt al-fiṭr?

a) After Fajr on ʿĪd, before the prayer b) After the ʿĪd prayer c) The first day of Ramaḍān d) A week after ʿĪd

12. In the Mālikī school, iʿtikāf requires:

a) Fasting, in a masjid b) Ten full days c) Being in Makkah d) Staying awake all night

13. Fasting the day of ʿArafah, for one not on Ḥajj, expiates:

a) Nothing b) The year before and the year after c) One week d) All sins forever

14. Which of these days is it forbidden to fast?

a) Monday b) The 15th of Shaʿbān c) The day of ʿĪd d) The 10th of Muḥarram

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) At night	8	c) Qaḍāʾ and a mudd a day
2	c) Once	9	b) No
3	c) Complete it, make it up	10	b) A ṣāʿ
4	a) Deliberately drinking	11	a) After Fajr on ʿĪd
5	b) Feeding sixty	12	a) Fasting, in a masjid
6	d) Qaḍāʾ and fidyah	13	b) Year before and after
7	a) Qaḍāʾ only	14	c) ʿĪd

For further study

- **Matn al-Akhḍarī** and **al-ʿAshmāwiyyah**, the chapters on fasting.
- **Ar-Risālah** of Ibn Abī Zayd, the chapter on fasting and iʿtikāf.
- **Al-Muwaṭṭaʾ** of Imām Mālik, the Book of Fasting and the Book of Iʿtikāf.

Duʿāʾ — Upon seeing the new moon

اللَّهُمَّ أَهِلَّهُ عَلَيْنَا بِالْيُمْنِ وَالْإِيمَانِ، وَالسَّلَامَةِ وَالْإِسْلَامِ، رَبِّي وَرَبُّكَ اللَّهُ

"O Allah, bring it over us with blessing and faith, with safety and Islām. My Lord and your Lord is Allah."

At-Tirmidhī (3451), who said: ḥasan gharīb.

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A month to come back to Allah.

This free guide from the Himaayah Madrasah explains the rulings of fasting according to the school of Imām Mālik, clearly and with the evidence, so you can enter Ramaḍān with knowledge.

- Who must fast, and who is excused
- The intention, and what breaks the fast
- What you owe: qaḍāʾ, kaffārah or fidyah, with a decision chart
- Zakāt al-fiṭr, iʿtikāf and Laylat al-Qadr
- The voluntary fasts of the year, and a Ramaḍān plan

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